

The Cardboard City Rescue

Big challenge · Indoors · Grown-up nearby · Ages 5–10 · 60 min

Brought to you by Mateo — “If it can be stacked, it can be a city.”

Build a city out of boxes, then find out which bridges survive when the storm rolls in.

WHAT YOU NEED

- A pile of boxes, big and small
- Masking tape
- Markers
- Safety scissors
- Anything recyclable that looks like a building

BEFORE YOU START

A grown-up cuts any thick cardboard.

Build low first. A tall tower that falls is not a disaster, but it should not fall on anybody.

How to make it

- 1 Sort the boxes into tall ones and flat ones. Tall boxes become buildings, flat ones become roads and bridges.
- 2 Lay out the roads first, then place the buildings along them. A city needs somewhere to go, not just somewhere to be.
- 3 Cut a strip of card and lay it flat across a gap to make your first bridge. Push down gently in the middle and watch it sag.
- 4 Now fold the same strip into a zigzag so it makes triangles from the side, and lay it across again. Push down again.
- 5 Rebuild your weakest bridge using the triangle trick.
- 6 Build a small rescue vehicle that has to cross every bridge in the city without any of them collapsing.

TALK ABOUT IT

Which bridge did you fix first, and how did you decide which one was the weakest?

TRY THIS TOO

Give the city a river made of blue paper and see how many different bridge shapes can cross it.

DID YOU KNOW? · SHAPES & STRUCTURES

Triangles hold their shape under pressure. Push on a square and it squashes into a slant. Push on a triangle and it stays a triangle, because none of its corners can move without one of its sides changing length. That is why bridges and roofs are full of them.